

Transition Rules

How to solve transition questions

- 1.) Identify the two ideas you need to transition between in the text.
- 2.) Determine the relationship between those two ideas.
- 3.) Determine the kind of transition needed.
- 4.) Determine the transition type of the answers.
- 5.) For any set of answers in which two or more answers have the same transition type as the type needed, consider the specific context of each.

General Structures of a Transition (for Boundaries)

1.) _____ ① _____. [Transition], _____ ② _____.

When the transition appears in the beginning of the sentence, it usually means that we are transitioning between **the sentence directly prior to the transition** and **the sentence that the transition begins**.

Ex.

I like hotdogs. Though, I prefer hamburgers.

2.) _____ ① _____. _____ ② _____, [Transition] .

When the transition appears at the end of the sentence, it usually means that we are transitioning between **the sentence before the sentence that the transition ends** and **the sentence that the transition ends**.

NOTE: If you struggle to remember these two, just remember that the transition is **always** in idea ② (which is in the sentence after ①).

Ex.

I like hotdogs. I prefer hamburgers, though.

Continuing Transitions

Continuing transitions indicate that the relationship between ① and ② is positive and that both ideas are working together to accomplish the same goal. In such a case, ② is “continuing” the idea presented in ①.

1.) Exemplifying

① is always a general claim

② is always an example illustrating the general claim

Common Transitions:

For example
To demonstrate

In particular
Specifically

For instance

Ex.

I like a lot of foods. For example, I like hotdogs.

2.) Additional Support

① is always an example or a reason

② is always another example or a reason

Often, the text will contain three sentences: the first being a general claim and the second and third being examples illustrating the general claim.

Common Transitions:

Additionally
Likewise

Furthermore
Similarly

Moreover

Ex.

I like a lot of foods. For example, I like hotdogs. Likewise, I also like hamburgers.

3.) Restatement

① is always a statement expressed in a particular way

② is always the same statement expressed in another way, often in the negative

Common Transitions:

That is
In fact

In other words
Indeed

Changing diction

This transition can appear as a direct paraphrase using different diction.

Ex.

I like hotdogs. In fact, glizzies are one of my favorite foods.

Double negative

A double negative, though rare, may be used to paraphrase the first sentence.

Ex.

I like hotdogs. That is, I don't hate them.

Outlier-Normal

A difficult version of this transition involves stating something unusual in ① and then explaining what is common in ②.

Ex.

I don't usually eat hotdogs for breakfast. Indeed, I typically eat hamburgers.

Definition

A definition means the same thing as the word it defines. It can therefore be used as a 'restatement' transition.

Ex.

I like hotdogs. That is, I like frankfurters served in long, soft buns and topped with condiments.

NOTE Restatement transitions always indicate the same idea between ① and ②.

4.) Chronological

① will usually come before in a temporal sequence

② will usually follow in a temporal sequence

The ideas do not need to go in the correct temporal order. It is just likely that they will move from past to present to future.

Common Transitions:

First
Before
Prior to this

Second
Now

Next
Last

Third
In the end

Then
Finally

Later

Ex.

For lunch, I had a hotdog. Later, I had a hamburger.

5.) Concluding

- ① will usually come before in a sequence
- ② will come at the end of the sequence, summarizing the prior sequence

The most common form of concluding transitions will usually refer to the sequence of a logical argument

Common Transitions:

in conclusion

Ex.

I've been looking at the menu. In conclusion, I've decided to order a hotdog.

Contrasting Transitions

Contrasting transitions indicate that the relationship between ① and ② is negative and that both ideas are working antagonistically to accomplish different goals. In such a case, ② is “contrasting” with the idea presented in ①.

Unlike the different types of continuing transitions, contrasting transitions will often use the same transition words. I will list any exceptions to the rule.

Common Transitions:

although
while
regardless

in contrast
rather
on the contrary

otherwise
even so
instead

however
conversely

1.) Disagreement

① will be some statement

② will be another statement saying the opposite

Ex.

I like hotdogs. However, I don't like hamburgers.

2.) The Counterexample

- ① will be a general claim
- ② will be an example that does not illustrate the claim

Ex.

I like a lot of foods. Although, I don't like hotdogs.

3.) The Other Option

- ① will be some possibility or explanation
- ② will be a different possibility or explanation

Often, such transitions will appear in texts with three sentences in which the first sentence is a general claim about the differences of something and the other two sentences demonstrate those differences.

Common Transitions:

On the other hand Alternatively

Ex.

There are two options for lunch: you could get a hotdog. On the other hand, you could get a hamburger.

4.) The Unlikely Conclusion

- ① will be some initial statement appearing first in a temporal sequence
- ② will be a conclusion that disagrees with the initial assumption

Common Transitions:

Ultimately

Nevertheless

Nonetheless

Ex.

My favorite food is hotdogs. Nevertheless, I decided to get a hamburger.

5.) The Exception

① will be a statement

② will be additional information that makes the original statement less likely or important

NOTE Unlike with other contrasting transitions, an exception indicates that both ideas are true.

Common Transitions:

Granted **That said**

Ex.

My favorite food is hotdogs. That said, I decided to get a hamburger.

Cause and Effect Transitions

Cause and effect transitions indicate that the relationship between ① and ② is such that ① is the “cause” of ②, the “effect”

1.) Cause and Effect

① will be a statement of some kind

② will be something that logically follows from that statement

Common transitions:

hence
thus
accordingly

consequently
as a result

therefore
to that end

for this reason
fittingly

NOTE You can often tell if a set of statements needs a cause and effect transition if you can read it as “Because ①, ②”

Ex.

My favorite food is hotdogs. Fittingly, I ate one for lunch.

Secret Transitions

“Secret” transitions will never appear as answers in **Transition** type questions; however, they can be quite useful for quickly grasping the meaning of dense and complicated texts in other question types such as **Inference** or **Qualitative Evidence** type questions. Acknowledging these as transitions and recognizing that the SAT uses them explicitly to transition between two ideas can make reading much easier and quicker.

, and - indicates that both idea ① and ② are true and that they **continue** with each other

, but - indicates that both idea ① and ② are true and **emphasizes** that they **contrast** with each other

, yet - indicates that both idea ① and ② are true and **emphasizes** that they **contrast** with each other

, or - indicates that ① and ② are options or possibilities that can be chosen between. This usually means it is **contrasting**.

, nor - indicates that ① and ② are options or possibilities and that neither of them are true or possible. This usually means it is **continuing**.

, so - indicates that ① is the **cause** of ②, the effect

, for - indicates that ② is the **cause** of ①, the effect

Colon (:) - indicates that ② will be an **example**, a **reason**, or a further **explanation** of ①. It is either **continuing** or **cause-and-effect**.